

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

LCA_Kenya_2024-25_3-month Report

Fellowship Organization

Lwala Community Alliance (LCA)

Fellowship City

Rongo

Fellowship Country

Kenya

Fellowship Start Date

08/12/2024

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/12/2025

What is your fellowship title/role?

Data Engineering Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Build and maintain integration of all data sources, such as Commcare, Salesforce, eCHIS, KoboCollect, RedCAP, PowerBI, Looker Studio, and other reporting systems
- Manage the creation and implementation of Power BI dashboards for ERP systems
- Conduct comprehensive research on data warehouse solutions for the organization's data transition, develop schema mappings, and formulate operationalization strategies
- Assist in writing the research protocol for a digital maturity study in Migori, the first of its kind

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Neutral

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

My onboarding was two-fold--there was an orientation designed by the past fellow and a separate orientation designed by HR. Overall, it took about a month, and I felt that it kept me from starting onboarding within my own department because I was told I should finish general onboarding first. Though I think it was somewhat disorganized (last minute meeting/visit cancellations), I met someone from every single department and received comprehensive introductions to every part of the organization. It helped in the future when I did collaborative work across departments.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

I usually go to the office, which is about 30 minutes away by car. If I don't have a morning meeting, I'll do emails and some coding practice for the skills I need to learn to work. I then do dashboard maintenance or data quality analysis and end the day with research. I take tea around 10 for about 20 min and lunch around 1:30 for about an hour.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

I wrote the background and literature review for the digital maturity study that Lwala is conducting in Migori county. It's the first study of its kind in the region. My work is helping to inform which digital maturity model and which indicators are used.

Another project I am working on is identifying a data warehouse for the organization to use to store all of our data.

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

The office is moderately big - has 3 floors and my department has its own cubicle. There are about 20-30 employees at the office.

To whom do you report?**Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?**

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

yes

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

Gain familiarity with technical issue resolving on eCHIS

Openfn learning

Data Reporting for the organization

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I went to Nyahururu for an all staff work retreat. I am also going this week to Nairobi to co-work with colleagues on a big deliverable we have coming up.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

I have to do a lot of self-learning which is fine, but there isn't a lot of room for mentorship here so be prepared to figure out most of it on your own.

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

My organization booked a one-way ticket on my behalf. It was from Washington DC to London to Nairobi. It cost around \$800. Do not recommend going through London because their TSA requirements are really strict and time-consuming.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I came in on a tourist visa, applied for a student pass, and my tourist visa was extended by two months while I wait for the student pass to clear.

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Through my HR Department. They apply for everything on my behalf.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

Lwala applied for my tourist visa before I arrived. The student pass was applied for after I had already arrived.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

No personal costs incurred, the organization paid.

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Covered by organization

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

you just have to stay on top of deadlines and follow up with the HR department to make sure they've submitted the documents.

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I got cholera, typhoid, polio booster, and chikungunya vaccines. The travel consultation was \$40 and my vaccinations were free because they were covered by my insurance.

I did not get the yellow fever vaccine because I was already vaccinated as a child. I also did not get the rabies vaccine because of the obscene cost.

If you're a costco member, highly recommend doing all your travel vaccines and the consultation through costco pharmacy. Their consultation is way cheaper than any other health clinic and the actual vaccines are cheaper as well, even paying out of pocket. Most travel clinics will make you pay out of pocket first, but costco will check your insurance.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

My arrival was quite smooth. I think I learned about my accommodations upon arriving very late (like day of), so just be patient and make sure to keep checking in if you're not organizing your own logistics.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is provided by the organization.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Rural

Please describe your living environment

We live in a small village. Most people know one another and greet each other as they pass by. It's very green with a temperate climate. There are dirt roads and cows.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I travel by car and transportation is covered by the organization

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

Shopping can be done in Kisii (about 30-45 min away). There are various local airports nearby (Migori and Kabunde airstrip, both about 1.5 hours away), but the largest is in Kisumu (about 2-3 hours away).

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

Currently in the rainy season, so it rains most days in the evening and is cool in the morning and evening. Otherwise, it is quite temperate. It's like an average summer day-around 70-80 degrees, and in both the dry and rainy season, there's a lots of sun.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Usually modest clothing is fine. Nothing too short and nothing strapless. Essentially what you would wear to work anywhere else. Outside of work, the same rules mostly apply. I've avoided anything too short or revealing.

How have you been spending your free time?

I read, walk quite a bit, and go on runs. Nearby there is a soapstone carving place where I take lessons from time to time. We often invite people to dinner or get invited to dinner. Socializing generally happens through people we meet through work, but once in a while on our walks, you can make friends.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response below.

Not really sure what my definition of success is, but it's pretty difficult to stay in touch with family and friends and not have a full day taken up that could also be spent with someone at my fellowship post. It's really hard to keep up with a lot of people individually, so highly recommend some sort of blog or newsletter.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I work and live in a safe area. We live within the hospital compound and the hospital has a 24/7 guard rotation. Generally safe.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I lock my door at night, and I don't walk alone after dark.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

Nothing really except some scam messages from people posing as coworkers on whatsapp

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

The village is so small, there aren't really areas of safety or not. You should always walk with someone else after dark.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

My three goals were improving my technical skills, learning swahili, and develop a cultural understanding of rural life in western Kenya. I feel that my first few months have mostly been research of project management tasks, so I have only developed my technical skills a little bit, and I hope to learn more as the year goes on.

I definitely have been slacking on my swahili study, and have only recently committed to daily practice. I hope to become a lot better as the year continues.

In terms of getting a better understanding of rural life, I think my experience here has definitely accomplished that. I think I could be more intentional about being out and about in the community and going into the field more rather than staying in the office.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

I think I've been quite frustrated with work. In my department it's pretty difficult to get information out of people. I feel like so much of my day to day is calling/texting/emailing someone three times for the same thing before I can start my task for the day. It's very exhausting, but it's best to just put everything on email, and move on to other things until they respond.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

Make sure to bring good mosquito repellent and sun screen as well as any hair products you need. Another thing might be any foreign condiments or seasoning. Everything else is very easy to find

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

Not particularly. My family is from Rwanda, and the cultures are somewhat similar. I think the hierarchy in the workplace has been a little bit strange to navigate. There are a lot of protocols and things you can't do without checking first with your supervisor.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I would consider this posting to be way less rural than I initially expected. We have hot water, a gas stove, somewhat consistent wifi, and a backup generator for power outages.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

I miss the convenience of being able to just get in my car and just go somewhere. Being in a rural area means that transport is quite expensive and you have to plan ahead. I also think initially the food felt quite monotonous, but now I cook my own meals a lot more. Obviously, language is a bit of a barrier, just because in most social settings people are often speaking Luo or Swahili. But basically everyone speaks a good amount of English. It's just always nicer to meet someone in their native language.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

variety of food
access to a car
lots of different available activities (movie theaters, plays, comedy clubs, parks, live music, etc.)

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

Fruit and general freshness of food
The weather is great
Value of rest time (tea breaks and long lunches)

How is your stipend being paid?

Monthly, US dollars to US account

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

ACH

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

After graduating college, I stayed at home and worked before the fellowship to save money. I don't currently work any additional jobs

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$50.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$30.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$4.00	\$0.00	\$80.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	84.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

Think the lack of an in person orientation really hampered the cohesion of the cohort, which made it difficult to create a support system among one another. I also just think it's harder to digest information while spending so much time on the screen.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

In-person! Best way to prepare is to develop a really solid support system of people who are experiencing the same thing.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?

yes

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

I feel that scheduling the fellowship retreat over the weekend was not ideal. Since we all have different leave plans, and while it has been clarified that the retreat itself doesn't count as leave days but any additional time outside the retreat does, this setup forces us to take more leave days than we might have otherwise.

Given that this retreat is one of the few opportunities for fellows from different regions to spend time together, this arrangement limits the possibilities for meaningful interactions and informal connections.

I also hope there's a significant amount of time dedicated to gathering feedback and discussing ways to improve the program. While opportunities for written feedback are provided, these discussions often happen more naturally and effectively in person.